

THE RINGLEADER
Nilesh Kumar alias PK (in red jacket) in police custody in Varanasi

CBI registered another FIR in September 2021 against one Parimal Kotpalliwar in Nagpur. The owner of an 'educational consultancy firm', he had allegedly arranged for five fake candidates to appear for NEET at four centres in Delhi and another in Ranchi. Likewise, the police in Rajasthan arrested one Rajan Rajguru, who allegedly stood second in the Rajasthan Pre-Medical Examination in 2010. He, too, was suspected of arranging a proxy for a NEET examinee. In 2021, the police also arrested Sandeep Saini in Ajmer, who was giving the examination for a NEET candidate in return for a fee. Six MBBS students of the Rajasthan University of Health Sciences (RUHS) and two students of a veterinary college and two kingpins were nabbed too.

In September 2019, CB-CID sleuths in Tamil Nadu arrested one Dr Venkatesh and his son Udit Suriya for having used a proxy for the NEET examination and getting admission into a medical college. Eight first-year students of medicine were arrested for recruiting proxies for NEET. Two brokers and seven parents, including a government doctor, were also taken into custody.

Then, of course, there is the long-running ghost of Vyapam, the scam that broke out in Madhya Pradesh in 2013, in which there were accusations of bribes being paid and proxy candidates being used to write the pre-medical tests for admission to medical colleges. The CBI has charge-sheeted over 3,100 accused in the scam so far. And based on the evidence, the trial courts have so far convicted about 100 accused in 36 Vyapam cases. On January 7, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) shared details of the five-year rigorous imprisonment awarded to the six accused—two impostors, two candidates and two middlemen—in the 2010 PMT conducted by Vyapam.

Failed Test

Already facing the challenges of an alleged leak of the 2021 question paper and criticism in a Tamil Nadu government-appointed committee report of the examination failing to provide equal opportunity to all, NEET now has to grapple with the surfeit of cases of proxy candidates. The common entrance examination for admission to MBBS, BDS, BAMS, BHMS and other undergraduate medical courses in approved medical, dental, AYUSH and other colleges, a record 1.6 million candidates had registered for NEET last year at over 3,800 centres in 202 cities.

A similar can of worms emerged in the JEE Mains held between August 26 and September 1, 2021. The CBI raided 19 locations across Delhi-NCR, Pune, Jamshedpur, Indore and Bengaluru and identified at least 30 students who appeared, allegedly fraudulently, for the exam. The JEE Mains is held for admission to undergraduate engineering courses such as B.E./ B.Tech at the IITs, NITs, other CFTIs (centrally-funded technical institutions) and certain institutions or universities recognised by some state governments.

Fatal Fallout

In October 2021, Keerthivasan, a 20-year-old student from Tamil Nadu, took his own life for fear of failing NEET. He was the fourth student in the southern state to commit suicide after taking the 2021 exam.

According to NCRB data, as many as 2,080 students (1,147 male and 933 female) died by suicide in 2020 for fear of failing in examinations. Jharkhand topped the list with 325 suicides, followed by 287 in Maharashtra and 235 in MP. Fourteen suicides were reported specifically in connection with NEET, up from seven in 2019.

And while one cannot directly blame the fake candidates for this surge in suicides, they do contribute to candidates succeeding through fraudulent means at the cost of deserving ones. The illegal racket also helps produce professionals unfit to handle critical jobs.

Scamproofing Exams

There are several levels at which proxy candidates can be filtered. While it is easier for the impostors to get past the entrance test, evaluation and ranking, they can be caught at the counselling stage or while being given seats during actual admission to the allotted institution.

"While the examination system already has several layers of verification, including photographs, physiological and biometric identification, fraudsters do manage to slip past," says a police officer in Varanasi, on condition of anonymity. Meanwhile, Julie, an otherwise bright student who would top almost all internal tests, is cooling her heels in judicial custody. She may not be able to become a doctor after all. There can be no irony greater than that. ■